Graduate Honours Interdisciplinary Seminars 2024-2025
Programme overview

1. General information

The *Graduate Honours Interdisciplinary Seminars* (GHIS) Programme is an extracurricular honours Programme for master students from all 7 faculties of the Utrecht University. A maximum number of 80 students can enroll in the Programme. GHIS carries 10 EC (~280 hours). These 'honorary' EC are not eligible to count as an elective in a regular degree Programme, meaning that you really take the extra mile on top of your Master.

Within the context of the Utrecht Universities ambition to educate a next generation of professionals that are better equipped to tackle complex challenges, the GHIS Programme has a broad explorative focus: e.g. exploring different disciplines; exploring more broad and dynamic collaborations; exploring inter-/ and trans-disciplinary research and skill sets; exploring the changing role of academia. GHIS specifically facilitates the interaction between students and researchers to jointly explore viable multi-faceted solutions in context of real-life cases. Examples of challenges that pass along include climate change, food scarcity, economic crises, health crisis, destabilizing countries and inequalities.

Learning goals within GHIS are focussed on giving students a better understanding of combined disciplines that are needed to tackle complex challenges. GHIS prepares students to understand the added value of interdisciplinary research and the added value of their own knowledge. You will come across various aspects of working in an inter-/trans-disciplinary context: e.g. becoming more familiar with research concepts from disciplines other than your core master programme; getting introduced to different research methods; learning to think about perspectives from different stakeholders. Students also obtain insight into obstacles researchers face and skills that are needed to design, and execute inter-/trans-disciplinary projects. Moreover you'll practice to communicate complex ideas and research findings with broad audiences. Taken together GHIS challenges you to broaden your horizon and explore the boundaries of your discipline, and your comfort zone in an interactive way.

The GHIS programme makes use of different forms of evening education:

Seminar series

Each student will follow 3 different seminar series in groups of ~10 to 15 students. You are encouraged to sign up for seminar series outside of your own faculty. For example, if you are a humanities student your preferences could include a session taught by for instance a psychologist or a chemist, but preferably not a historian nor a philosopher. If you have an interdisciplinary background, you'll be encouraged to choose a topic out of your comfort zone and expertise.

The format of the seminars is fluid. The professors and researchers whom you are working with will inform you about their structure by a high-over infosheet and more details are provided during the first session. To give you an expression of what to expect:

- **First meeting**: Introduction to the research field and the research of the professor(s) in that field. Some reading may be assigned before (e.g. academic articles, news reports or both);
- **Middle meeting(s)**: An introduction to a more specific problem/research question of contemporary focus. The students engage in considering this issue from their disciplinary perspective and in doing so an assignment is formed. In a potential follow-up, professor and students work together to try and form an interdisciplinary solution to what was originally a disciplinary research question;
- **Last meeting:** The students present their assignment. This is often some form of presentation, debate or creative task such as a blog, a news article or a cartoon strip. Ideally, assignments are not long written pieces of work, unless it deviates significantly from the written form involved in your masters research (i.e. dense academic evidence-based prose). Insights, reflections and contributions will be collected to be assembled in a yearbook.

A list of topics and dates is shared a few weeks before each block: areas to expect throughout the year can include for instance: Digital sustainability and Artificial intelligence, Pros and Cons of working within Academia, Behavioral economics , Capitalism, Religion, International Migration, Social dilemmas, Lifecycle medicine, Skills for changing the world, and much more. (*The second seminar series will include a an online series for students doing an internship abroad focusing on broadening their research projects.)*

Excursion + starting point for disciplinary and personal grounding

A weekend excursion is part of the programme to get to know each other better while obtaining inspiration, interactive learning and fun. The trip takes place Autumn 2024 and 2 options are provided:

- The first option is the **Texel island trip taking place November 09-10**. You will take the train ~8:20 in Utrecht CS to Den Helder. There you hop on the boat to the Island Texel. You return Sunday evening around 19:00 at Utrecht CS. Travel (train and boat), accommodation (Stay Okay hostel), breakfast and dinner are included (Drinks, snacks, lunch are excluded).

  On Saturday you'll practice "Perceiving" during an adventures bike trip, which we will jointly reflect on. The evening program you can organize yourself with the group of students. Think of a pub quiz or playing games. On Sunday morning we'll have a session in which you start exploring your personal positionality within and beyond your discipline and your learning ambitions in terms of interdisciplinary skills. You will monitor and discuss these personal goals with peers throughout the year. After the joint session you go on a site visit (e.g. museum visit, guided nature tour or more free time). After which you hand in your bikes to catch the boat back to Den Helder, latest around 16:00 so that you arrive back in Utrecht before 19:00.

- For those that are having busy schedule and cannot make it Nov 09-10, **a more compact option will take place in Utrecht Nov 16th**. Similar to the Texel trip, this option also covers the "perceiving" bike trip but with a smaller site visit incorporated. Also we will jointly reflect on the bike tour and provide space to discuss your personal positionality within and beyond your discipline and your learning ambitions in terms of interdisciplinary skills. The UItrecht option has less travel and less "free time" and is therefore more compact. It starts at 9:30 in the city center library and ends around 17:00. Lunch is included as well as an optional meal afterwards for those that can stay after 17:00.

Joint thematic sessions

The joint sessions have various purposes (e.g. facilitate to meet the entire group of GHIS students, reflect on and discuss the followed seminars with one another, dive deeper into specific topics, and provide feedback or ask questions to the GHIS team). The sessions allow to focus more specifically on general orientation and skills. The year starts with a general kick-off meeting (Oct 2nd) providing more details on what we'll do and what to expect. The follow-up joint sessions are spread over the year helping you to gain basic insights on disciplinary, interdisciplinary and transdisciplinary practices including its challenges and value. The exact content of these sessions is tailored towards the ambitions and needs of the specific group of students in your year (We'll make an inventory during the kick-off event.). Topics of previous year included an escape room game about integration, a communication evening, academic leadership/open science, and group-work related topics.

Group Project

Starting ~Dec/Jan, you'll form a group of students with which you will design an inter/trans disciplinary product. The year will be wrapped up by presentations and reflections about these groupwork projects. The format of the products can be tailored towards your ambitions. You'll all start from a self-chosen research oriented topic which could result in the design of a new research proposition, the interpretation of research for instance by a podcast round table discussion or documentary. Also you could work towards of the proposition of a research spin-off idea such as a specific recommendation or a tool or product (think about creating an actual prototype, building a stakeholder engagement plan and/or you can put your own creativity to the table).

2. Learning objectives

After having followed the GHIS programme, you will be able to:

- Explain effectively the value of interdisciplinary research to disciplinary peers;
- Understand the added value of your disciplinary knowledge in context of complex challenges;
- Select the optimum methods (theoretical, qualitative, quantitative or mixed) for an interdisciplinary study and produce a sound rationale for that choice;
- Identify and contribute to the establishment of different perspectives in a critical debate on an interdisciplinary topic;
- Produce and deploy successful problem-solving strategies, bringing to bear creativity and interdisciplinary knowledge;
- Work constructively and meaningfully in a team of researchers from vastly different disciplinary and international backgrounds on a final assignment that demands interdisciplinary skills (e.g. collaboration, integration and communication);
- Communicate complex ideas and research findings with broad audiences;

3. Year Schedule

Organized meetings will take place in the evenings in the city centre of library of the Utrecht University (Drift) or at the Utrecht Science park (Uithof). All joint sessions start at **18:00 and last till ~20:30** On top of this you will engage in groupwork, social activities and individual work which you can plan yourself. Here the overview of the year:

- Wednesday October 2nd Kick-off meeting, Utrecht Science park library, Boothzaal
- between Oct 7th and end of November: first seminar series. 3 or 4 evenings scheduled either Mon, Tue, Wed or Thu (The exam week of Nov 6-nov 10 is kept free.) Your specific schedule will depend on the chosen seminar series (see separate list of topics)
- Weekend excursion (option 1 Texel Nov 9-10, option 2 Utrecht Nov 16-17)
- Wednesday Dec 4, Joint sessions (disciplinary grounding part 1), Science park library, Boothzaal
- Wednesday Dec 11, Joint session (disciplinary grounding 2), Science park library, Boothzaal

Holiday break

- Wed Jan 15th , Joint session (groupwork & collaboration skills) Science park library, Boothzaal
- Wednesday Jan 22nd , Joint session on integration techniques, location tbd
- Start period 3: ~Feb-mid March sem series 2
- Wednesday March 26 , joint session theme tbd
- Wednesday April 2nd , joint session groupwork in the Playground (Science park)
- Start period 4:~Late April-May sem series 3
- Wednesday June 4th, Joint session theme tbd & final groupwork products ready
- Wednesday, June 18th: Final GHIS event in the Playground (Science park)
- Thursday July 3rd: Graduation ceremony in The Aula, University Hall (Academiegebouw)

4. Examination

Students that complete all parts of the Programme will obtain a GHIS certificate and the 10 extracurricular EC. To complete activities your active attendance and contribution according to the assigned tasks is mandatory. Co-creation is central to all honours activities meaning that you'll be asked to actively prepare for meetings and jointly contribute to the content and discussions of the sessions. Absence is allowed with good reasons and timely communication with the GHIS team and the involved lecturer and fellow students involved in the affected activities. For certain activities an alternative assignment and/or extra reading can be provided. Up to 2 absences will not affect your ability to obtain a certificate but above that it can jeopardize your ability to successfully complete the programme. In case of any unforeseen circumstances or personal emergencies though we will more thoroughly discuss if and how you can keep on track and make arrangements accordingly.

5. What commitment to GHIS means

✓ Intrinsic motivation to learn about inter and transdisciplinary research and concepts;
✓ Willingness to explore your comfort zone and learn beyond your own discipline;
✓ A respectful, collaborative and open-mindset towards people with different (and sometimes conflicting) perspectives and experiences than yours;
✓ Prepared participation in meetings and active contributions to discussions and activities;
✓ To be enrolled in a UU master programme in the academic year 2023-2024 and physically present at seminars and meetings, unless otherwise specified/approved (e.g. incidental online participation, alternative assignment). When you are going to miss a meeting, you should communicate your reasons with the GHIS team and involved lecturers/fellow students in advance.

Looking forward to welcoming you and accompanying you on the GHIS experience!

Best wishes,

The GHIS team,
Gillina Bezemer, Elena Voeten, Neeharika Sadhukhan (Mimi)